

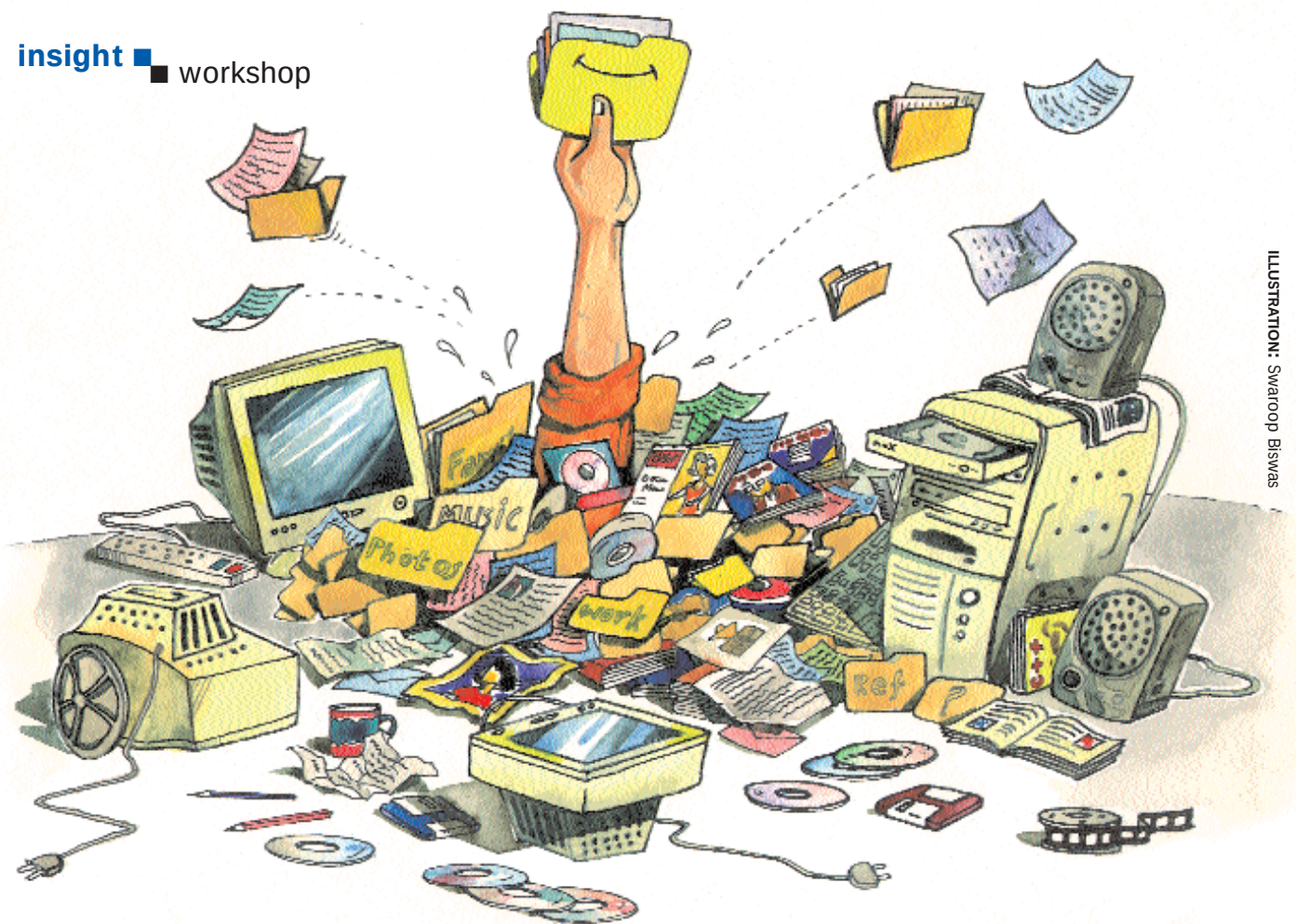


ILLUSTRATION: Swaroop Biswas

Organise your CHAOS

It's very likely that you have large volumes of documents, both at home and in the office, that are in disarray for want of a systematic process to organise and share them. Try out the document management system to see what it can do for you

“What's in a name?” asked Shakespeare once. A lot, especially if it's a vital document that your boss has asked for. Scrounging through the reams of folders on your computer will drive you crazy. We've been taught to organise electronic documents in folders, the way it's done in filing cabinets. The hierarchical file system (HFS) has long been a logical way of storing electronic documents.

The HFS subjects the future behaviour of the user to his/her original logic on how to lay out the directory tree. Hence, even the Find feature may not be of much help when all you remember is that you do have such a document named 'something' lying 'somewhere'. You need an

expert to organise your files in a meaningful manner that will help instant retrieval. What you need is a Document Management System (DMS).

A document records information. Information is more than data, so a document includes elements of contextualisation, organisation and analysis. Document Management involves managing documents through their lifecycle—from creation, review, storage and dissemination, right to their destruction.

The first thing is to document the management operation (by way of a meta document). Each document type (record series) retains a list of the creator, a brief description, method of indexing, location, retention period and reason for the reten-

tion period assigned. Records may then be placed in sub-groups to further classify the records. A DMS classifies, stores and records the progress in terms of changes made to your files in a systematic manner, making retrieval easy and efficient.

Getting your act together

While there are plenty of paid options that you can experiment with, you could start with Qdocs—a full-version single-user freeware that works with Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Visio, Publisher, Acrobat Reader, WinZip, eBook, Twain Scanners and image files. It is an add-on to MS-Office that organises your documents using a profile which generates an Automatic Reference Number, and asks for a